PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3

Texture

Listen to a piece and ask: how many lines are sounding at once, and how do they fit together? That is its **texture**.

THE SECRET

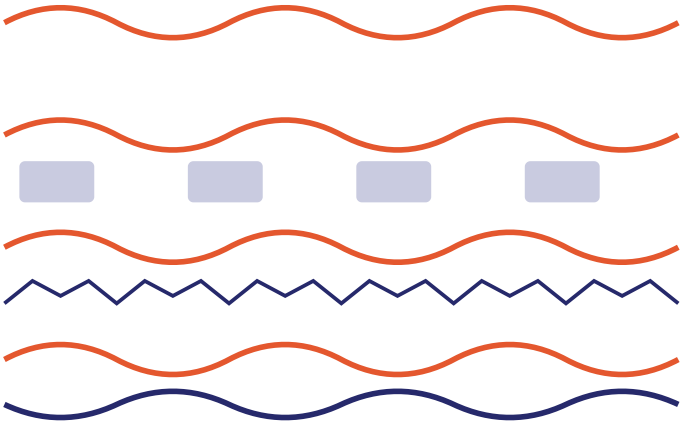
Count the lines: one alone, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together.

one line
monophony

a tune with chords
melody and accompaniment
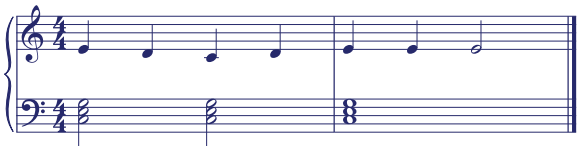
a tune over broken chords
Alberti bass, arpeggios

two tunes at once
polyphony
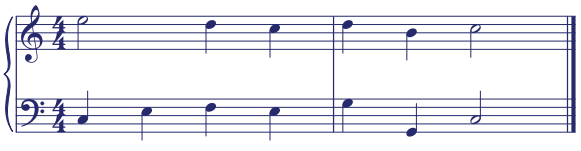


Thin or thick: count the threads

WORD	WHAT YOU HEAR
monophonic	one line alone, or in octaves (unison)
homophonic	a tune with chords underneath: melody and accompaniment
polyphonic (contrapuntal)	two or more tunes at once, each its own
Alberti bass	a broken chord rocking low–high–middle–high
block chords	all the chord notes struck together



Melody and block chords.



Polyphony: two tunes, each with its own rhythm.

GAME

One line or more?

1	2	3
a tune alone	a tune and chords	two tunes at once

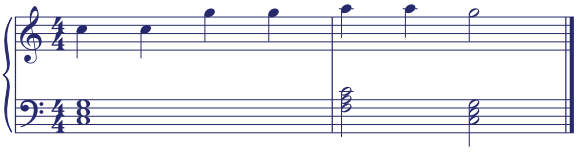
Name the texture.

Answer: 1 monophonic · 2 homophonic · 3 polyphonic.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Name the texture
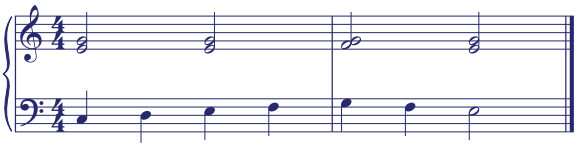


1. **The right hand:** a tune or chords?
2. **The left hand:** a tune or chords?
3. **So** which word?

A tune over chords: **homophonic**, melody and accompaniment.

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand has the tune?
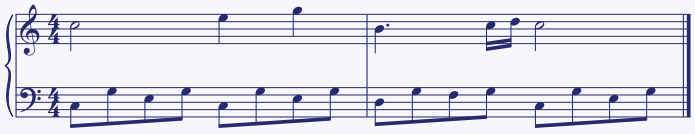


1. **The right hand** repeats two-note chords.
2. **The left hand** moves step by step.
3. **Which one** should sing out?

The **left hand** has the tune: play it louder, keep the right-hand chords soft.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545



The right hand sings; the left hand rocks **C G E G**: an Alberti bass, the sound of the Classical style.

Try it. Play only the left hand, softly and evenly.

TRAP

- × Letting the accompaniment cover the tune: tune louder, chords softer.
- × Losing one of two tunes: practise each hand alone and sing it.

SEE ALSO
Chords under a melody p. 142 · Styles p. 159

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Library › Texture